



Beyond the economic benefits, GI tags play a crucial role in **preserving India's rich cultural heritage**. Each handloom product with a GI tag tells a story of **traditional skills, histories, and cultural identities** specific to a region. This preservation of traditional craftsmanship is vital in a rapidly modernizing world. By protecting these crafts through GI tags, India not only safeguards its **diverse cultural tapestry** but also ensures the transmission of age-old skills and knowledge to future generations. This cultural preservation is key in maintaining a sense of continuity and identity for many communities. The pride associated with producing GI-tagged items often revitalizes interest and pride in traditional crafts among younger generations, ensuring that these precious skills do not fade into obscurity. In a broader sense, GI protection helps in maintaining the **cultural diversity of India** on the global stage, promoting cross-cultural understanding and appreciation of India's artistic heritage.

India's Diverse Tapestry of Regional GI-Recognized Handicrafts Across States

Of the India's rich tapestry of **over 514 registered GIs**, a significant portion—**more than 275**—belong to the **handicraft sector**, which includes **handloom textiles**, a testament to the country's rich textile traditions and skilled craftsmanship. These GI tags cover a variety of categories that not only represent the handloom sarees but also a myriad of other handicrafts, reflecting the geographical diversity and unique cultural identity of each Indian state. Uttar Pradesh leads with **39 GI Tags**, a reflection of its prominence in intricate handlooms, including the Banarasi Sarees. Following closely, Tamil Nadu has **35 tags**, underscoring the state's heritage in producing exquisite handloom textiles like Kancheepuram Silk. The diversity extends across India with states like **Karnataka and Rajasthan** holding 19 and 17 GI tags, respectively, showcasing their unique regional handicrafts and textiles.

Gujarat, Kerala, and Odisha with 15 GI tags each, highlight their rich tradition in both handloom textiles and other handicrafts. Other states contributing to this rich tapestry include **Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana and West Bengal**, each with 14 GI tags, displaying a range of products from traditional sarees to metal crafts. **Jammu & Kashmir, Bihar and Uttarakhand**, among others, also contribute significantly to this list, each bringing their unique handloom textiles and artisanal goods to the national and international markets under the protection of GI tags. The GI tags serve as a beacon of authenticity and originality in a competitive global marketplace, empowering artisans through **recognition and premium pricing**, which is crucial for the sustenance of traditional crafts and the communities behind them. For instance:

- **BANARASI SAREES:** Banaras, a city in Uttar Pradesh, is renowned for its exquisite handloom sarees, known as Banarasi sarees. These sarees are characterized by their rich embroidery and renowned for their gold and silver brocade or zari, fine silk, and opulent embroidery. They symbolize the epitome of Indian handloom craftsmanship and are often part of significant occasions like weddings. The GI tag has played a pivotal role in preserving the unique identity of Banarasi sarees. It has helped in differentiating the authentic, handcrafted sarees from machine-made imitations, thereby protecting the livelihoods of local artisans. The recognition has also led to an increased demand both domestically and internationally, contributing significantly to the region's economy.
- **CHANDERI FABRIC:** Hailing from Chanderi in Madhya Pradesh, this fabric is known for its lightweight, sheer texture, and luxurious feel. Traditionally woven in silk and cotton, Chanderi fabrics are distinguished by their fine zari work and elegant motifs.
- **KANCHEEPURAM SILK:** From the town of Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu, this silk is famous for its durability and lustrous beauty. Characterized by vibrant colours and temple-inspired motifs, Kancheepuram silk sarees are considered auspicious and are preferred for ceremonial wear.
- **KASHMIR PASHMINA:** Kashmir Pashmina is another stellar example of GI's impact. Known for its fine cashmere wool, this hand-spun and woven textile from the Kashmir Valley has gained international fame. The GI tag ensures that only Pashmina made according to traditional methods in Kashmir can be labelled as such. This has not only preserved the artisanal purity and authenticity of the product but also aided in fighting counterfeits, thus securing the artisans' economic well-being.

SAFEGUARDING INDIA'S GEOGRAPHICAL INDICATIONS (GI): A Robust Legal Framework

India's legal framework for the protection of Geographical Indications (GIs) is **comprehensive**, encompassing both international agreements and national laws. At the international level, India is a signatory to the Agreement on **Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS)**, which is administered by the **World Trade Organization (WTO)**. TRIPS sets down minimum standards for the protection and enforcement of various forms of intellectual property, including GIs. This international agreement obligates India to provide legal means for protecting GIs and ensuring that they are not misleading to the public or used in a manner detrimental to their rightful owners. At the national level, the cornerstone of GI protection in India is **the Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration & Protection) Act, 1999**. This act was a significant step in aligning **India's intellectual property laws** with international standards as mandated by the TRIPS agreement. It lays down the criteria for what constitutes a GI, the procedure for its registration, and the scope of protection provided. The Act enables the producers of GI-tagged goods to **prevent unauthorized use** of the registered GIs by others, which is crucial in maintaining the integrity and uniqueness of the product.